

Definitions of power

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A working list of definitions.

Power

Power is the capacity to bring about outcomes — by acting directly, by shifting another agent’s behaviour, by setting the conditions under which others act, or by producing agents and possibilities that didn’t exist before. It comes in five overlapping forms: *power-to* (capacity to act at all), *agentic power* (one agent shifts another, against resistance), *structural power* (a system shifts behaviour with no one willing it), *constitutive power* (the power to set the structure others operate inside), and *generative power* (the power to produce new agents, capacities, desires, or possibilities). The English word “power” smears across all five; pulling them apart is most of the work.

Power-to

Power-to is the capacity to act — to do, to make, to bring something about — independent of any relation to another agent. A solo inventor who builds a working prototype has power-to without exercising power over anyone. Most everyday uses of the word “empowerment” mean power-to.

Unpacked:

- *No second agent required.* Power-to is one-place; the other three forms in this entry are at least two-place. A castaway alone on an island has power-to (light a fire, build a shelter) and nothing else.
- *Substrate of the other forms.* You can’t shift B’s behaviour, sustain a structure, or write the rules without first being able to act. Loss of power-to (illness, poverty, imprisonment) collapses your access to the other kinds.
- *Often the thing actually wanted.* When people demand “more power” in their own lives, they usually mean power-to, not power-over. The two get confused because in a zero-sum framing they look identical — but most of the time they aren’t zero-sum, and conflating them turns growth into domination by default.
- *Distinct from rights.* A right is a social claim that others not interfere; power-to is the underlying capacity. A right to free speech without a platform, audience, or safety to speak is a thin kind of power-to.

Agentic power

Agentic power is the capacity of one agent (or coordinating collective) to shift another agent’s behaviour toward outcomes the first prefers, against the second’s resistance, across some domain.

A collective counts as an agent here only to the extent it has coherent preferences and can act on them — a union with a strike vote qualifies, a “demographic” does not. There is no general way to combine many individual preferences into a single group preference without losing something along the way, so “the group wants X” is usually a faction’s preference standing in for the whole.

Unpacked:

- *Capacity, not exercise.* Power is a disposition — it exists whether or not it is used. An unfired gun is still a threat; an unspent fortune still constrains the people who might need it later.

- *Counterfactual.* A has power over B in domain D to the degree that B's behaviour in D tracks A's preferences more than it would in A's absence. No counterfactual gap, no power.
- *Against resistance.* Influence that operates only through B's existing wants (persuading B of something B already half-believed, or offering B something B already wanted at a fair price) is not yet power. Power shows up where preferences diverge.
- *Domain-relative.* Power is always over some set of choices. A landlord has power over where a tenant sleeps but not over what they read. Conflating domains ("the powerful" as a class) hides where the leverage actually sits.
- *Mechanism-agnostic.* The shift can be produced by force, by control of resources B needs, by control of information B uses, or by shaping the options B can even see. These are different *kinds* of power, not different things.
- *On measurement.* Power resists reduction to a single scalar, but not measurement as such. Within a fixed domain it is often quantifiable — how often a voter's bloc is decisive, how concentrated a market is among its top firms, what share of wealth sits with the top percentile, how often a subordinate complies when told. What can't be measured is the *general* quantity, and the reasons fall straight out of the definition above: power is counterfactual (you'd need the world without A), domain-relative (no single scalar covers every domain at once), and mostly latent (unexercised capacity leaves no trace in the data).

Structural power

Structural power is the capacity of a system — a market, a bureaucracy, a body of law, a norm, a piece of infrastructure — to shift agents' behaviour against their preferences, without any agent willing the shift.

The observable signature matches agentic power: B's behaviour in domain D diverges from what B would choose unconstrained. The difference is in the counterfactual. For agentic power, *removing A* restores B's freedom. For structural power, there is no A to remove; the constraint survives the departure of any individual participant. A worker taking a low wage is not coerced by their employer (who may be replaceable, sympathetic, even underpaid themselves) but by the labour market — a structure with no author.

Unpacked:

- *No first agent.* The defining feature. Structural power often originates in past agentic choices (a law was written, a city was zoned), but once embedded it operates independently of anyone's current will. The agent who could change it may no longer exist, or may face the same structure when they try.
- *Aggregative.* Structural power is usually the macro-shadow of many micro-decisions, none of which individually shifts B. Each landlord setting rent at market is acting reasonably; together they constitute a constraint no single one of them imposes.
- *Invisible by default.* Agentic power has an antagonist; structural power has only a situation. People living inside it tend to experience the constraint as a fact of the world rather than a thing being done to them. This is what makes it durable.
- *Substrates.* Markets (prices coordinate without a coordinator), bureaucracies (rules outlive rule-makers), norms (defaults shape behaviour before anyone deliberates), infrastructure (the built environment makes some actions easy and others impossible — a highway routed through a neighbourhood constrains everyone downstream of that decision long after the planner is gone), language and categories (what is sayable bounds what is thinkable), path dependence (early choices lock in late constraints).

- *Resistance is collective or it fails.* Because no single agent is the constraint, no single agent can be pushed back against. Changing structural power requires changing the structure — coordinating enough participants, rewriting the rules, building alternative infrastructure — which is hard for the same reason the structure is durable.
- *Convertible to agentic power.* Agents who understand a structure can position themselves inside it to extract agentic power from it (the landlord who buys when the zoning is about to change, the lobbyist who writes the rule, the platform that sets the defaults). Structural and agentic power are distinct concepts but in practice each feeds the other.

Constitutive power

Constitutive power is the capacity to set the structure that other agents then operate inside — to write the rules, pick the defaults, design the platform, draw the map. It is agentic in form (someone wills the structure into existence) but its effect runs through structural power (once embedded, the structure shifts behaviour without further input). It's the bridge between the two.

Examples: the legislator drafting a tax code, the founder choosing the opt-in versus opt-out default, the engineer designing a road network, the standards body picking a file format, the early user-norm that hardens into “the way things are done here.”

Unpacked:

- *Highest leverage per unit effort.* Acting directly shifts one situation. Shifting an agent shifts one relationship. Setting a structure shifts every interaction the structure mediates, for as long as it lasts. One unit of constitutive power often buys years of downstream structural leverage.
- *Front-loaded and rarely revisited.* Structures get set once, under specific conditions, and then carry forward by inertia. The people present at the founding have a disproportionate say in what everyone after them has to work with. By the time the structure is visible enough to argue about, the moment to shape it is usually past.
- *Often invisible while being exercised.* Writing a default, drawing a boundary, or naming a category looks like description rather than decision. The constitutive move is easier to make when no one yet sees it as a move.
- *Distinct from agentic power within the structure.* A senator voting on a bill exercises agentic power. The lobbyist who wrote the bill's framing exercises constitutive power. They can be the same person at different moments, but they are different kinds of move and they reward different skills.
- *Decays into structural power.* Once the structure is embedded and the constitutive agent is gone, what remains is structural power with no author — which is why old constitutive choices are so hard to undo. Reversing them requires fresh constitutive power, which is itself rare.

Generative power

Generative power is the capacity to produce new agents, capacities, desires, identities, or possibilities — to bring into existence things that weren't there before, rather than to shift, constrain, or arrange what already is. The other four forms operate on a given set of agents and options; generative power changes that set.

Examples: an education that doesn't just transfer information but produces a different kind of person; marketing that creates a desire where none existed; a category like “teenager” or “consumer” that, once named, produces people who think of themselves that way; a scientific

paradigm that produces what counts as a question worth asking; a platform that produces new kinds of work (the streamer, the creator, the gig driver) by making those roles possible.

Unpacked:

- *Productive, not restrictive.* The standard image of power is something stopping you from doing what you want. Generative power runs the other way: it gives you wants, capacities, and self-conceptions you wouldn't otherwise have had. It expands the world rather than constricting it — which is why it often doesn't register as power at all.
- *Operates on the agent, not on their choices.* Agentic power leaves B intact and shifts B's behaviour. Generative power changes who B is — what B wants, what B is capable of, what B even sees as an option. The same external behaviour can come from coercion (agentic) or from desire (generative); the difference is whether the desire was there before the power acted.
- *Hardest to resist.* By the time you can identify yourself as a subject of generative power, it has already made the “you” who would resist. There is no pre-shaped self standing outside the shaping to push back from. This is why generative power is the most durable of the five, and the most contested in critical theory.
- *Dual-edged.* Generative power produces both the literate citizen and the addicted consumer, both the scientist and the conspiracy theorist, both the empowered worker and the precarious one. The fact that something is generated rather than imposed doesn't tell you whether it expands or narrows the resulting person's power-to.
- *Overlaps with constitutive and structural, but distinct.* Constitutive power sets the rules existing agents operate inside; structural power is the rules running on their own. Generative power makes agents with new capacities and desires for those rules to operate on. A school's curriculum is constitutive; what the curriculum makes of the student is generative; the school system as a self-sustaining institution is structural.

Egalitarianism

An egalitarian society, in the language of power, is one that simultaneously raises the floor of power-to, caps concentrations of power-over, distributes constitutive power broadly, and biases structural power toward enabling rather than constraining. Four dials, not one — a society that wins on any single dial while losing on the others is not egalitarian.

The temptation is to compress this into a slogan (“maximize power-to, minimize power-over”). That misses three things: some power-over is generative (teaching, parenting, contract enforcement) and removing it collapses the activity rather than freeing anyone; power-to itself can be used to harm others' power-to, so “more” isn't the target — “more, distributed, non-subtractive” is; and a society that equalises power-to and suppresses power-over can still be unfree if a small group writes all the rules.

Unpacked:

- *Floor, not average.* Power-to should be evaluated at the bottom of the distribution, not at the mean. A society where average capacity rises while the worst-off lose ground is regressing on this dial even if the aggregate looks good. The relevant question is what the least-empowered person can do, not what the most-empowered person could.
- *Cap, not eliminate.* Power-over isn't binary-bad; it's concentrations that matter. An egalitarian society tolerates the surgeon, the referee, and the teacher exercising power-over within their domain, and refuses to let any one agent accumulate uncontested, durable power-over across many domains at once. The target is to prevent *domination*, not to abolish authority.

- *Distribute the rule-writing.* Constitutive power is the dial most often left out, and the one that quietly determines the others. A society where everyone has equal power-to within rules written by a few is only as egalitarian as those rules. Broad participation in setting defaults, drawing categories, and writing law is itself an egalitarian condition, not a separate political question.
- *Structure as ally or enemy.* Markets, infrastructure, and institutions can either raise the floor (roads, courts, public education, healthcare) or lower it (debt traps, exclusionary zoning, monopolised platforms). Same substrate, opposite sign. Egalitarianism here means actively shaping structures so that their default operation expands power-to for the many rather than concentrating it for the few.
- *The dials interact.* Raising the floor of power-to without capping power-over lets the well-resourced convert their gains into domination. Capping power-over without distributing constitutive power just freezes the current rule-set in place. Distributing constitutive power without aligning structural power leaves participants writing rules inside a system that overrides them. The dials have to move together or they undo each other.
- *Not the same as equality of outcomes.* This definition is about the distribution of *capacities and constraints*, not of consumption. Two egalitarian societies on this definition could differ widely in income or wealth; what they share is that no one is structurally prevented from acting, dominated by another, locked out of rule-making, or living inside a system actively narrowing their options.

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is the property that makes power voluntarily accepted by those subject to it. Legitimate power runs on compliance; illegitimate power runs on enforcement. It is a property power can have, not a sixth form of power — any of the kinds in the power entry can be legitimate, illegitimate, or contested.

Two senses of the word, which routinely get confused:

- *Descriptive legitimacy.* A's power is legitimate iff those subject to it actually accept it as rightful — they comply without needing to be coerced each time. This is a fact about beliefs and behaviour. It can be measured by what people do when no one is watching.
- *Normative legitimacy.* A's power is legitimate iff it meets some external standard — consent of the governed, procedural fairness, justice of outcomes, rightful authority. This is a claim about what power *ought* to be acceptable, independent of whether it actually is.

The two come apart in both directions: a regime can be widely accepted (descriptively legitimate) but unjust by any defensible standard (normatively illegitimate) — most stable tyrannies have this shape. A regime can also be normatively legitimate by some standard yet rejected on the ground — most failed reform projects have this shape. Most political argument is one side appealing to one sense while the other answers with the other.

Unpacked:

- *Legitimacy is a compliance discount.* Illegitimate power has to monitor, threaten, and punish; legitimate power doesn't. This is why regimes invest so heavily in producing legitimacy (ceremonies, narratives, education, elections) — it's vastly cheaper than producing enforcement at the same scale. A power that has to be enforced everywhere all the time has effectively run out.
- *Sources of descriptive legitimacy.* Consent (explicit or tacit), procedural fairness (the right process was followed), outcome quality (it produces good results, or at least not bad ones),

tradition (it has always been this way), charisma (this particular holder is special), and identity (it was decided by “us”). Real regimes mix several; pure types are rare.

- *Maps onto every form of power.* Agentic power is legitimate when B accepts A’s right to shift their behaviour in domain D — a referee in a game, a doctor in a consultation. Structural power is legitimate when the constraint feels “natural” or “the way things are” rather than a thing being done to anyone. Constitutive power is legitimate when the rule-making process itself is accepted as rightful — who got to write the rules and by what authority. Generative power is the hardest case: legitimate roughly when the subjects produced by it endorse what they’ve been made into, but they can only judge from inside the shaping.
- *Contested, not binary.* Legitimacy comes in degrees and is unevenly distributed across a population. A government can be legitimate to one region and not another; a manager can be legitimate to half the team. The interesting question is rarely “is this legitimate?” but “to whom, on what grounds, and under what conditions does that withdraw?”
- *Withdrawable.* Descriptive legitimacy is not given once and kept; it is renewed continuously by ongoing compliance and revoked when compliance breaks down. The moment of revocation often looks sudden from outside (a regime that “seemed stable” collapses in weeks) but is usually the visible surface of a long, quiet erosion.
- *Not the same as legality.* A law passed by the correct procedure is legal; whether it is legitimate is a separate question, in either sense. Legal-but-illegitimate power (a procedurally valid but widely rejected ruling) is the engine of most reform movements; illegal-but-legitimate power (a strike, a sit-in, a coup welcomed in the streets) is the engine of most revolutions.